nuclear and ballistic missile plans without U.S. aid, and Pakistani scientists felt almost as optimistic in pushing their Islamic bomb agenda under Dr. A. Q. Khan's direction at the Kahuta Research Laboratory. To the rest of the world, however, the prospect of any exchange of nuclear missiles between the two neighbors, whose deadliest weapons could reach each other's capitals and major cities in less than ten minutes, was too terrifying to contemplate.[3]

So most world leaders, British, Russian, and Chinese, as well as American, tried their best to persuade both Vajpayee and Sharif to reach peaceful agreements on all outstanding Indo-Pakistani conflicts as swiftly as possible. Prime Minister Vajpayee took the hopeful initiative, therefore, in February 1999 of driving across Punjab's border at Wagah to meet with Prime Minister Sharif in Lahore.

That "Spring Summit of Friendship" between Vajpayee and Sharif was greeted with black flags by thousands of angry militant Pakistanis, who cursed both leaders and did their worst to darken horizons that had briefly looked bright over Lahore's heavy old Mughal fortress. The two leaders did their best, however, to present cheerful faces to the press, agreeing to seek in a series of future meetings to resolve all outstanding disputes, including the thorniest—the conflict over Jammu and Kashmir. It almost sounded too good to be true, and soon after Vajpayee returned home to his heavily burdened desk in New Delhi, he was outraged to hear of Pakistani aggression in the northern Kashmir region of Kargil.

General Pervez Musharraf, who had been elevated to chief of army staff (COAS) by Nawaz Sharif in October 1998, prided himself on his martial daring and tactical boldness in the field. Hence, without informing his prime minister, Musharraf took it upon himself to order Pakistani troops to occupy icy Indian-built bunkers on the Line of Control in Kargil; these were occupied by Indian troops for most of the year and vacated by them only during the coldest months of each winter. As soon as Vajpayee learned of this treacherous move, he called Sharif on their hotline, angrily demanding an explanation of what had inspired such a blatant violation of the Indo-Pakistani Simla Summit Accord. Sharif protested complete ignorance of the move, however, insisting that the army had acted without his prior knowledge or authorization.

As the ice began to melt in Kargil that June, India started to attack the occupied bunkers with heavy artillery, troops, and planes, and by mid-July, Pakistan had lost more than a thousand men. Soon Vajpayee proclaimed India's victory to cheering crowds in New Delhi. President